



■ STARTUP FAILURE #003 · MONDAY

Koo. The buzz was real. The business never was.

Series · Startup Failure (Mon)

Date · 03 Aug 2026

Subject · Koo

Framework · A moment is not a moat

01 Carousel caption (posts 08:00 IST)

Koo had 60 million users, cabinet ministers posting daily, and a valuation near \$275 million. Two years later it was gone. And it didn't die because it couldn't beat Twitter.

Koo was a made-in-India, multilingual answer to Twitter, built by Aprameya Radhakrishna and Mayank Bidawatka. In 2021, when the Indian government clashed with Twitter over blocking certain accounts, ministers and celebrities publicly jumped to Koo overnight. A patriotic wave carried it. Downloads went vertical. It looked unstoppable.

Here's the problem. It was built on a moment, not a business. A download spike isn't a business. The users came because of a news cycle, not because Koo had something they couldn't live without. When the moment passed, so did the growth.

And the economics never worked. Social media is brutally expensive, servers and content moderation cost a fortune, and Koo never cracked how to make money from any of it. It raised around \$50 million, hit a paper valuation of \$275 million, crossed 60 million downloads, and still had no real revenue model.

When the funding winter hit, it had nothing to fall back on. Buyers looked, then walked, because no one wanted the cost and legal liability of moderating user-generated content. Merger talks collapsed. Salaries went unpaid from April 2024. Koo shut down in July 2024.

The lesson: a moment is not a moat. Growth you don't control, with no path to revenue, is rented, not owned. Build the business, not just the buzz.

💬 Be honest, did you ever actually use Koo? Comment YES or NO.

❤️ Save this before you chase your next viral moment.

📖 Sources: TechCrunch, Forbes, Wikipedia, The Secretariat

⚠️ Editorial analysis of publicly available information.

#startup #startupfailure #koo #startupindia #founders

SEO Keywords (one line, comma-separated, for captions, alt text, cross-posting, YouTube/blog)

koo app, koo shutdown, why koo failed, koo vs twitter, aprameya radhakrishna, mayank bidawatka, koo app india, made in india social media, koo failure, indian startup failure, koo valuation, social media startup failure, koo funding, twitter rival india, startup burn no revenue, virality vs moat, koo case study, indian startup shutdown 2024, startupsutra startup failure, koo microblogging



02 Reel caption (evening · single reel, reversal hook)

REEL · REVERSAL HOOK

Everyone thinks Koo died because it couldn't beat Twitter. It died because it was built on a moment, not a business.

In 2021, when India clashed with Twitter, ministers and celebrities jumped to the made-in-India app overnight. 60 million downloads, a \$275 million valuation. But a download spike isn't a business.

Social media is brutally expensive, and Koo never cracked how to make money. When funding froze, buyers walked, no one wanted the cost of moderating user content. It shut in July 2024.

💬 Did you ever actually use Koo? YES or NO.

📖 Sources: TechCrunch, Forbes. Editorial analysis.

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03 Alt text 7 slides

1. Startup Failure, Koo. 60 million users, ministers on board, then it was gone; and it didn't die because it couldn't beat Twitter.
2. Snapshot: Koo, a multilingual made-in-India Twitter rival founded by Aprameya Radhakrishna and Mayank Bidawatka, peaked near a \$275 million valuation and shut down in July 2024.
3. The rise: in 2021 India clashed with Twitter, and ministers, celebrities and lakhs of users jumped to the made-in-India app overnight, downloads went vertical.
4. The flaw: it was built on a moment, not a business; a download spike isn't a business, and when the news cycle moved on, so did the users.
5. The economics: Koo raised about \$50 million, hit a \$275 million paper valuation and 60 million-plus downloads, but never built a real revenue model, and social media's server and moderation costs are brutal.
6. The end: funding froze, buyers walked because no one wanted the cost and liability of moderating user content, merger talks collapsed, salaries went unpaid from April 2024, and Koo shut in July 2024.
7. The lesson: a moment is not a moat; growth you don't control with no path to revenue is rented, not owned, so build the business, not just the buzz. Follow @statupsutra, Startup Failure on Mondays.

04 Hashtags, Stories & timing

CORE

#startup #startupfailure #koo #startupindia #founders

EXTENDED

#madeinindia #socialmedia #twitter

#entrepreneurship #india #casestudy #startuplessons

#venturecapital #tech

Comment engine (week-2 fix, 0 comments): pin "Be honest, did you ever actually use Koo? YES or NO." as first comment. Stories: teaser "60M users and ministers, then it vanished 🏹" → poll "Did you ever use Koo? Yes/No".

LOCKED SCHEDULE (IST)

TIME	ASSET
08:00	Carousel , slides 1 to 7
~18:00	Story teaser
20:00	Reel (reversal hook)
20:05	Story poll + pin comment

One reel only. Reply to every comment within the hour.